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BUSN 198 R

Assignment 3: Reflections and Lessons from the Internship

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This summer, I worked as a Social Media Intern at Barstool Sports in Chicago, where I spent 40 hours per week in person over the course of 11 weeks. In this role, I managed content across Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat, and X to promote Barstool's brand and products, including T-shirts, hats, hoodies, and food items. My daily responsibilities included monitoring social media trends, drafting posts, and collaborating with media personalities to create product advertisements. I also had the opportunity to observe content creators executing brand deals with clothing and beverage companies. This experience gave me a behind-the-scenes perspective on how sponsored products are integrated into digital content. Overall, the internship provided me with firsthand exposure to how a high-energy, fast-paced media company operates, while also showing me how social media functions as both a creative outlet and a business growth tool.

Over the course of the internship, I learned valuable lessons that connect directly to consumerism and retail. One of the most important lessons I learned was how much digital media influences consumer behavior. Social media exposes audiences to advertisements daily, often without them even realizing it, through posts and opinions from content creators. I also learned the importance of staying true to a brand's voice. Barstool's loyal fanbase is drawn to its unique humor and tone, and I saw how maintaining that voice in advertisements and product promotions built trust and

increased purchases. Another lesson was the importance of responding in real time. Social media trends and breaking news required immediate action, and I realized how valuable it is to collaborate quickly and efficiently in order to stay relevant. Finally, I learned about customer segmentation. With so many different personalities and podcasts under Barstool's brand, each audience had merchandise preferences. For example, "Pardon My Take" merchandise appealed to a very different fan base than "Megan Makin Money," and Barstool capitalized on these differences by tailoring products to specific audiences.

Some of the surprises during this internship were the creative freedom I had, the blending of business and entertainment, and how much emotional connection was linked to customer loyalty. First, at this internship, I was expecting to arrive on my first day and be given a PowerPoint on my responsibilities and what to do, but it was quite far from that. I was told that I had a large amount of creative freedom, and I was encouraged to come up with various ideas daily, even if they failed. They prioritized creativity and amount of content, which was a surprise for me. The more creative the advertisements and social media posts, the better the posts performed. Another surprise for me was how much entertainment was blended with business. Although everyone in the office was having a good time and being themselves, they were also working full time and constantly coming up with new ideas that would do well on digital platforms and sell more products. Lastly, I had not acknowledged the extremely large fan base that Barstool has, and its correlation to how loyal their listeners and customers are, which helps them do well. This can also be seen in different retail stores or

businesses. The stronger connection a consumer feels to the brand, the more likely they are to buy things from that brand and continue to do so.

The skills I developed during this internship will be extremely valuable in positioning myself for future job interviews, particularly in retail and merchandising. These include adaptability, team collaboration, sales through marketing, and experience in maintaining and understanding brand voice. First, I had to learn to quickly respond to shifting consumer demands, which is a key skill for retail management and merchandising. I can talk about learning to react to pop culture news, trends, and breaking sports, which all related back to the products we were advertising and the social media posts we were crafting. Another huge aspect of this internship was collaboration. From day one, I got to know basically every person in the office. We created content daily with different people in the office; the content creators, other social media interns, marketing interns, etc. Even though some people were higher up on the totem pole, we still worked together to make Barstool thrive. Each of us had a unique role in the process of putting content together and coming up with ways to sell merchandise. Also, I learned about sales through marketing. Within this internship, I also shadowed the marketing department and learned about media planning, brand deals, and partnerships. That was extremely helpful in understanding the multifaceted aspects of Barstool Sports. Lastly, this internship gave me experience with understanding brand voice. As I stated earlier, Barstool is popular for their unique voice and personality, which was crucial for me to understand when I was coming up with ideas for social media. This applies to several retail and merchandising jobs, because it

is very important to understand your audience and maintain your brand voice when creating and advertising products. For example, Chanel looks nothing like Urban Outfitters. Both are successful in different ways, but they have completely different customers, and need to maintain their brand voice to sell their products. Urban outfitters should not try to be Chanel, and Chanel should not try to be Urban Outfitters, because neither would be successful.

In terms of the EMPAC model insights, I noticed several parallels to retail organizations. Barstool Sports thrives on entertainment. Each post, video, and podcast is designed to capture the audience's attention and make them laugh. This parallels how general retailers use store design or campaigns to keep the audience/ the shoppers engaged and buying their products. In terms of matching, the content we were creating had to align with the audience's expectations, which was more of a sports and humor driven tone. Retailers will match certain products to target demographics and create a fit between shopper and item. I also saw this with the products we were selling. As mentioned, certain merchandise was created for specific fans, displaying the podcast logo or phrase that those people want to represent or show off. Although I was not directly involved in the pricing of the items we would advertise, I saw how content was tied into promotions. For example, I was in charge of posting about promotions on our cheesesteak company and our apparel. This mirrors how retailers post to highlight limited time drops or discounts, showing how pricing strategies can be communicated creatively. Barstool also offered a wide range of content and products. This included different podcasts, videos, merchandise, and event coverage where they would sell

apparel or food. This reflected how retailers curate a variety of products to appeal to different customers. Lastly, our content and merchandise was available across multiple platforms, through social media or internet browsing. This made it easy for the audience to engage however they wanted. This also reflects how retailers meet customers where they are and bring products to them in the easiest way possible, like online, in-store, or mobile apps.

In conclusion, my internship at Barstool Sports taught me valuable lessons about the intersection of digital media and retail. I learned how consumer behavior is shaped by content, how brand voice builds loyalty, and how creativity and data work together to drive sales. The experience also strengthened my skills in adaptability, collaboration, and strategic thinking. Most importantly, it showed me how essential it is to balance creativity with business goals in order to deliver value both to customers and to the company. These lessons will be beneficial as I pursue future opportunities in retail and merchandising.